The battlecruisers were soon engaged in bitter earnest. Beatty closed with the German force at speed, neglecting to exploit the superior range of his guns. Hipper's ships opened fire first, with a clear view of their targets silhouetted against the westering sun. With good range-finding equipment and armor-piercing shells, the Germans recorded hit after hit on the Royal Navy ships. First *Indefatigable* and then *Queen Mary* exploded and sank, each taking almost her entire crew to the bottom. Beatty's flagship *Lion* and the other battlecruisers all took hits. It was some relief when the battleships of 5th Battle Squadron tardily arrived, but before they could have any decisive impact the High Seas Fleet loomed into view.

Still unaware of Jellicoe's Grand Fleet drawing ever closer, Scheer believed a major victory was in his grasp. Beatty's battlecruisers turned northward, both to flee Scheer's battleships and lead him to Jellicoe, but the balance of losses continued to tip heavily against the Royal Navy. As elements of the Grand Fleet caught up with the battle, the battlecruiser *Invincible* and the armored cruiser *Defence* were sunk as they charged heroically into the thick of the action. Meanwhile Jellicoe, still unsure of the exact location of the German ships in worsening visibility, deployed the Grand Fleet in line of battle behind the battleship *King George V*.



Jutland medal
The Victoria Cross—Britain's highest award for valor—bestowed posthumously on Jack Cornwell after Jutland.

THE MAIN FLEETS ENGAGE

Scheer emerged from the murk to be confronted by the capital ships of the Grand Fleet spread out across his bow in a line 6 miles (10 km) long. From the moment the guns of the British battleships opened up on his leading ships, the German admiral had only one objective: to escape back to harbor. The High Seas Fleet turned 180 degrees behind a smokescreen to disengage. As Jellicoe maneuvered to cut off their retreat to the south, the German battleships ran into the Grand Fleet again, then dodged to the west, deploying a screen of torpedo boats and cruisers to deter pursuit.

Controversially, Jellicoe turned away to avoid the torpedoes, letting Scheer's fleet disappear in fog and smoke. As night fell, Jellicoe was confident that he could force a decisive battle the following morning. But in the darkness Scheer drove his fleet full tilt through the rear of the Grand Fleet's line. The night was sporadically lit by searchlights, star shells, gunfire, and burning ships as confused clashes occurred here and there. There were more losses on both sides. However, Jellicoe failed to grasp that Scheer was escaping and remained on the wrong course until the following morning, when he received the disappointing news that the German fleet was all but home.

In the immediate aftermath of the battle, the Germans were jubilant, and the British bitterly disappointed. The performance of the Grand Fleet drew howls of rage from the jingoistic British press. While the Germans had materially the better of the encounter, however, the Royal Navy remained in command of the North Sea.

1900–1916

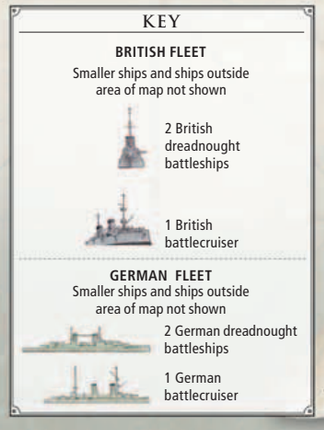
"JACK" CORNWELL

HERO OF JUTLAND

A working-class boy from the East End of London, John Travers Cornwell volunteered for the Royal Navy at the age of 15. He qualified as a Boy Seaman First Class and was assigned to the light cruiser *Chester*. At Jutland on May 31, 1916, he was a sight setter on one of the ship's 5.5-in guns. *Chester* came under heavy fire from four German warships, reducing her deck to a shambles. By the time the cruiser withdrew from the action, Cornwell was one of only two survivors of his gun crew. Although badly wounded by shell splinters, he was still at his post awaiting orders. Cornwell died two days later, aged just 16. He was posthumously awarded the Victoria Cross and celebrated as a British war hero.



> "THERE'S SOMETHING WRONG WITH OUR BLOODY SHIPS TODAY."
>
> **SIR DAVID BEATTY**, COMMANDER OF THE BRITISH BATTECRUISER SQUADRON



First Battlecruiser Squadron
Beatty's flagship *Lion* and battlecruisers *Princess Royal* and *Queen Mary* steam through the waters off Jutland shortly before the sinking of the *Queen Mary*.